

Week 16 – World War 2 & the Holocaust:

Source 1 – Excerpt from a Tasmanian newspaper, *The Mercury*, from the 23rd of June 1941:

THE MERCURY

HOBART: MONDAY, JUNE 23, 1941

HITLER MAKES WAR ON RUSSIA

GERMANY has followed her concentration of large forces on the Russian frontier by a proclamation of war and the invasion of Soviet territory, owing to the rejection of the German ultimatum. What demands were made are not known precisely, but they may be assumed to have included the return of Bessarabia to Rumania, and the, granting of extensive rights to Germany in the Ukraine.

Hitler has lost little time in again instancing the folly of accepting his pacts of friendship. In 1939, with flourish of trumpets, he announced amity established between the Soviet and Germany. Within a week or two he had invaded Poland, with whom he had a pact of friendship and non-aggression. He has carefully, in the interim between the sack of Poland and the present time, pretended to placate Russia, while making himself as secure as possible in the west. Only last January another pact of friendship with Russia was made, stated to be "in a spirit of mutual understanding." Now he tears up yet another scrap of paper and makes another war.

The factors that have brought about the war with Russia are fairly plain. Hitler has depleted his oil resources and his wheat supplies, and Russia is the only region from which he can hope to make good his deficiencies. We know nothing of the negotiations that took place relative to such supplies, but the result is proof that the situation is sufficiently urgent to make it worth Hitler's while to spread the war to get them. Furthermore, if Germany succeeds by an early smashing blow in gaining these objectives, the way will be open to Iraq, Iran, and India—the old German dream. It would be dangerous optimism to believe that the turn of events may not have disadvantages. It is doubtful if the Soviet war machine is well enough equipped or trained to withstand the highly organised armies of Germany, which have had nearly two years of war service. The experience of Finland did not rouse admiration for the qualities of the Russian Army, and it is questionable if the time has been long enough to reorganise and equip it as it should be equipped to meet the deadly efficiency of the Germans.

Hitler's proclamation of war with Russia was the usual tissue of lies. He took the opportunity to say that Britain's policy of encirclement had brought about the war, and then bewailed the consequences of the Russo-German pact which, he said, were "terribly hard." But the titbit of his absurd ravings was when he said that Bolshevism was opposed to National Socialism "in deadly enmity." This is the man who pretended to have sunk ill-feelings and made friends with the Bolsheviks. Is there one country left that can be beguiled by this specious trickster? Fresh and delicate situations are likely to be created as the result of extension of the war.

Source 2 – Heinrich Himmler speaking to leaders of the SS at Posen in October 1943

I also want to talk to you quite frankly about a very grave matter. We can talk about it quite frankly among ourselves and yet we will never speak of it publicly... I am referring to the Jewish evacuation program, the extermination of the Jewish people. It is one of those things which is easy to talk about... Most of you will know what it means when a hundred corpses are lying side by side, or five hundred, or a thousand are lying there. To have stuck it out and, apart from a few exceptions due to human weakness, to have remained decent, that is what has made us tough. This is a glorious page in our history and one that has never been written and can never be written... We had a moral right, we had a duty to destroy this people which wanted to destroy us... All in all we can say that we have fulfilled this most difficult duty for the love of our people. And our spirit, our soul, our character has not suffered injury from it.

Source 3 – Remarks made by Adolf Hitler in 1922:

As soon as I have the power, I shall have gallows after gallows erected, for example in Munich on the Marienplatz... Then the Jews will be hanged one after another, and they will stay hanging until they stink. They will stay hanging as long hygienically possible. As soon as they are untied, then the next groups will follow and that will continue until the last Jew in Munich is exterminated. Exactly the same procedure will be followed in other cities until Germany is cleansed of the last Jew.

Source 4 – Excerpts from Neal Ascherson's 'Review of Christopher Browning, *The Origins of the Final Solution*', *The Observer*, 23 May 2004

Few historians now think Hitler, insane Jew-hater as he was, planned the gas chambers before he even came to power. But neither do they think that struggles inside the Nazi structure led to Auschwitz almost without human agency.

...

Even Browning's researches have not turned up the fatal Hitler order. Probably none existed. That was not his way. Hitler preferred 'the best man, who bothers him least', henchmen who read his mind but took their own initiative. He filled the air with fearsome innuendo, but left it to junior figures to put into practice what they sensed he wanted – and what they wanted too. Afterwards, he would exult and take credit.

1. Explain the historical context of Source 1.

Source 1 relates to the German invasion of the Soviet Union, named Operation Barbarossa, which began on the 22nd of June 1941. Despite being ideological enemies, Nazi Germany and the Soviet Union had signed a non-aggression pact in 1939 in which they agreed to carve up Poland between them, not to fight each other and for the Soviet Union to provide certain materials to Germany. Both sides knew this was a temporary truce though, and in 1941 Hitler ordered his armies to invade the Russia in pursuit of *Lebensraum* / Living space and resources. The invasion began on June 22 and despite numerous warnings, the Soviet Union was unprepared. More than three million German troops in three separate army groups invaded on a front hundreds of miles long. The Germans pushed the Russians back and made it to the suburbs of Moscow. The first major counterattack by Russia began in December 1941 and from then, years of bitter fighting ensued, ultimately leading to millions of deaths on both sides. The turning points came in 1943 with the Battles of Stalingrad and Kursk and ultimately Germany was pushed back to and defeated in Berlin in May 1945.

2. Compare and contrast the messages of Source 2 and Source 3.

The message of Source 2 is that 'the extermination of the Jewish people' was a difficult task but one which was a moral duty that Germany needed to fulfill. The message is also that this amounted to a 'glorious page' in Germany's history and one which, although it can never be written about, the SS should be proud of.

The message of Source 3 is that, according to Hitler in 1922, if he managed to achieve power, he would execute all the Jews of Munich and then Germany 'until Germany is cleansed of the last Jew'.

The messages are similar in that both relate to the Jews and what Germany should do to / with them, specifically that they should be exterminated until there are none left. The perspectives are similar too as Source 2 is that of Heinrich Himmler, head of the SS, and Source 3 is that of Adolf Hitler, leader of the Nazi Party, hence their similar messages.

The messages differ in that Source 3 is from 1922 and is Hitler speaking of what he will do if he ever achieves power, whereas, Source 2 is from 1943 and is Himmler congratulating and reassuring the SS that they have done the right thing. The message of Source 3 is also concerned only with Germany's Jews, whereas, Himmler was referring to Jews more broadly in Europe.

3. Evaluate the usefulness, in terms of strengths and weaknesses, of Source 2 and 3, regarding the impact of the idea(s) represented.

Source 2 and 3 relate to anti-Semitism and Nazi policies towards the Jews. Source 2 is part of speech given by Heinrich Himmler to the SS in 1943 about the extermination of the Jews. It is particularly useful as it is from the perspective of the head of the organisation tasked with carrying out the Final Solution, which gives an interesting insight into the way top Nazis attempted to justify their crimes as a moral duty which was for the benefit of the nation. This perspective and bias is also a limitation though, as Himmler was obviously a long time Nazi and was speaking at this time with a clear purpose in mind – to motivate and encourage the SS to complete the difficult task of the extermination of the Jews. Source 3 is a remark made by Adolf Hitler in 1922 about what he will do to the Jews if he ever came to power. It is useful as an insight into the way Hitler, the leader of Nazi Germany and key determinant of Nazi policy towards the Jews, thought in the early days of the Nazi Party. It is particularly interesting and useful when considering the origins of the Holocaust and the extent to which Hitler originally intended to exterminate the Jews as it is from Hitler himself. This source clearly implies Hitler intended to wipe them out as far back as 1922. Source 3 is limited too though due to bias and by the fact that Hitler often used vitriolic rhetoric, making it hard to know how far we can use the source.

Both sources are very useful in getting an insight into the way top Nazis responsible for carrying out the Holocaust thought of Jews and what they should be done to / with them. Their bias in this case is what makes them so useful as long as we are aware of it.

4. Identify and account for the authors' perspectives in Sources 3 and 4 regarding the idea or event represented.

Both Source 3 and 4 relate to the Nazi's treatment of the Jews. The author of Source 3 is Adolf Hitler and his perspective is that the Jews of Germany should all be executed. The reason for this perspective is first and foremost because it is that of Adolf Hitler. Hitler was anti-Semitic and blamed Jews for all the issues that had befallen Germany by 1922, including Germany's defeat in World War 1 and the political and social chaos that followed. He believed that to restore Germany to its rightful place in the world, it needed to rid itself of the Jews and protect the master race, hence his hateful perspective. By 1922 Hitler was the head of the Nazi Party and was agitating to enact his party's programme, a central plank of which related to the Jews and aimed to exclude them from German society. The author of Source 4 is Neal Ascherson and the source is an excerpt from a review he wrote of historian Christopher Browning's book *The Origins of the Final Solution*. Ascherson's perspective is that the Holocaust occurred due in part to Hitler's desires as well as those of his henchmen, who attempted to curry favour with Hitler by taking the initiative and doing what they thought he wanted them to do. Ascherson is responding to and critiquing Browning's work, partly addressing what Browning has found or not found, that is, an order from Hitler explicitly ordering the Holocaust. As a result, Ascherson's perspective appears to be balanced and based on his knowledge of the history and Browning's work.